The Stewardship Gap:

Turning Acknowledgment Into Relationship

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StratusLIVE

Speakers

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Agenda

- The Gap — why stewardship falls through the cracks
- Your CRM as a stewardship engine
- The four pillars of a proactive calendar
- Pillar deep-dives: Milestones, Impact, Recognition, Engagement
- Common pitfalls and how to avoid them
- A 5-step build plan and 30-day quick start
- Group exercise + Q&A

1

The Gap

Why stewardship falls through the cracks — and what your donors experience instead.

The Uncomfortable Reality

57%

of first-time donors never give a second gift

3×

more expensive to acquire a donor than retain one

80%

of lapsed donors say no one made them feel their gift mattered

<48h

response window before a new donor loses connection

Acquisition and renewal are strong. Stewardship is where the relationship breaks.

Data Source: Fundraising Effectiveness Project.

What Donors Actually Experience

✓ WHAT SHOULD HAPPEN

- Thank-you within 48 hours
- Impact update at 90 days post-gift
- Milestone recognition (anniversary, birthday)
- Stories about people their gift helped
- Invitation to engage beyond giving

✗ WHAT OFTEN HAPPENS

- Generic auto-receipt email
- Silence until the next appeal
- No memory of when or why they gave
- Form letter with 'Dear Friend'
- Next contact: a new ask

Audience Pulse Check

"Quick show of hands —
how many of you have a formal stewardship calendar today?"

✓ Yes, we have one

~ Partially — some touchpoints

○ Not yet, but it's on our list

✗ No stewardship calendar exists

Discussion: What's the biggest barrier to building one?

SYNC

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2

Your CRM as the Engine

The data you need is already there. The question is whether you're using it.

The Donor Lifecycle — Where Stewardship Lives

THE GAP

01 — Acquisition
First gift secured

02 — Engagement
Welcome & thank-you

03 — Stewardship
The gap most orgs miss

04 — Re-engagement
Keep them connected

05 — Renewal
Next gift conversation

Most organizations invest heavily in 01 and 05. Step 03 is where loyal donors are made — or lost.

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Your CRM as a Stewardship Engine

Three categories of data that power your stewardship calendar

Giving History

- First gift date & amount
- Giving frequency & cadence
- Designation preferences
- Campaign history
- Year-over-year trends

Engagement Signals

- Event attendance
- Volunteer activity
- Email opens & click-throughs
- Peer-to-peer participation
- Survey responses

Personal Milestones

- Giving anniversary
- Birthday month
- Years as a donor
- Cumulative giving threshold
- Upgrade moments

What Good Stewardship Data Looks Like

A CRM-ready donor record has all three layers populated — most orgs are missing at least one.

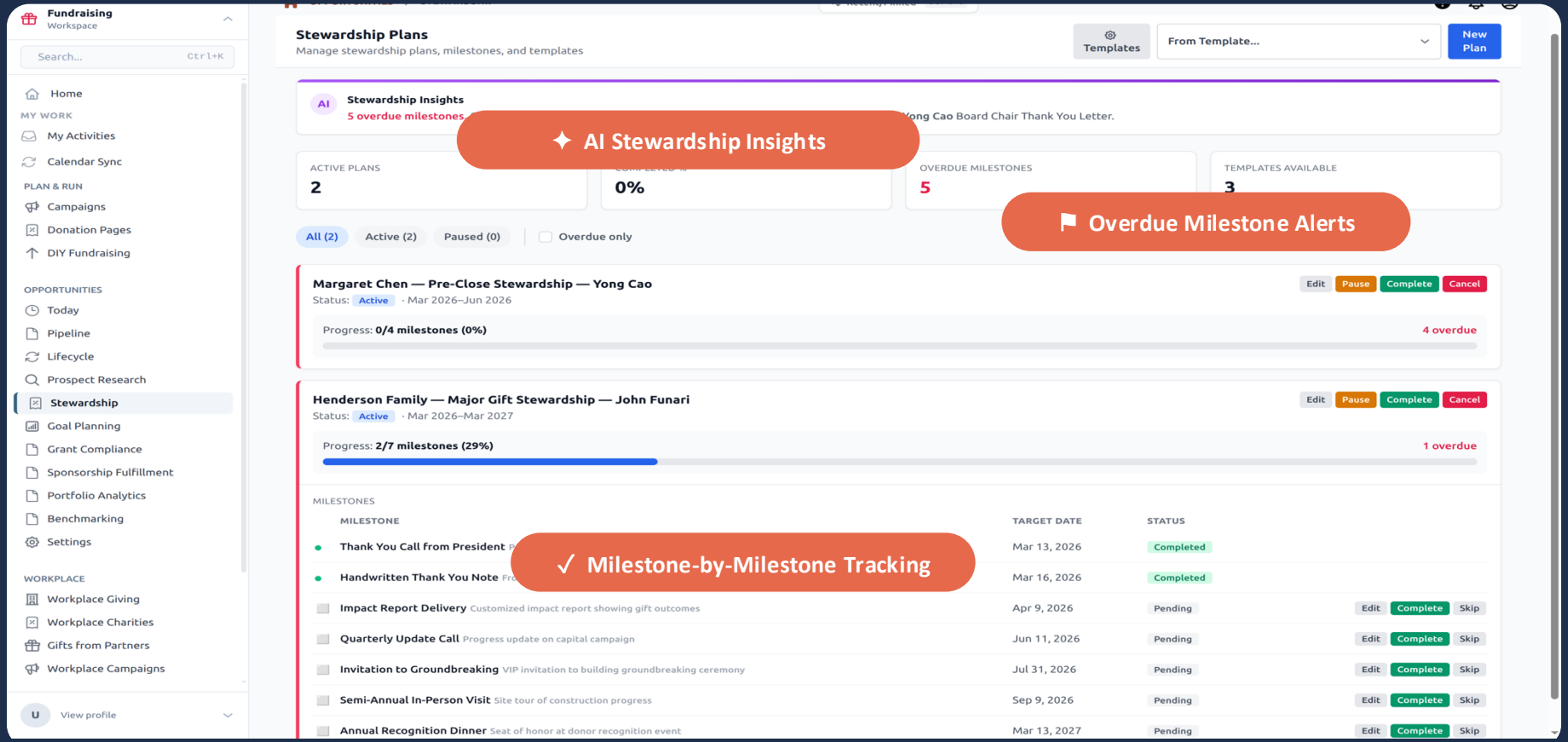
DATA GAP: What's missing

- First gift date not captured or not usable
- No designation codes on gifts
- Birthdays and milestones not in the CRM
- No engagement score or activity history
- Thank-you sent — but no follow-up calendar set

DATA READY: What to aim for

- First gift date field populated & indexed
- Designation code on every gift record
- Birthdate or giving anniversary in contact record
- Email engagement tracked via CRM integration
- Stewardship workflow triggered at gift entry

Stewardship Plans — AI-Guided, Milestone-Tracked



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The Four Pillars

A framework for making donor touchpoints intentional, not accidental.

The Proactive Stewardship Calendar

A framework for making donor touchpoints intentional, not accidental

01

Milestone Triggers

Automated by CRM data: anniversaries, giving thresholds, birthdays

02

Impact Updates

Curated content tied to what they funded — not a generic newsletter

03

Recognition Moments

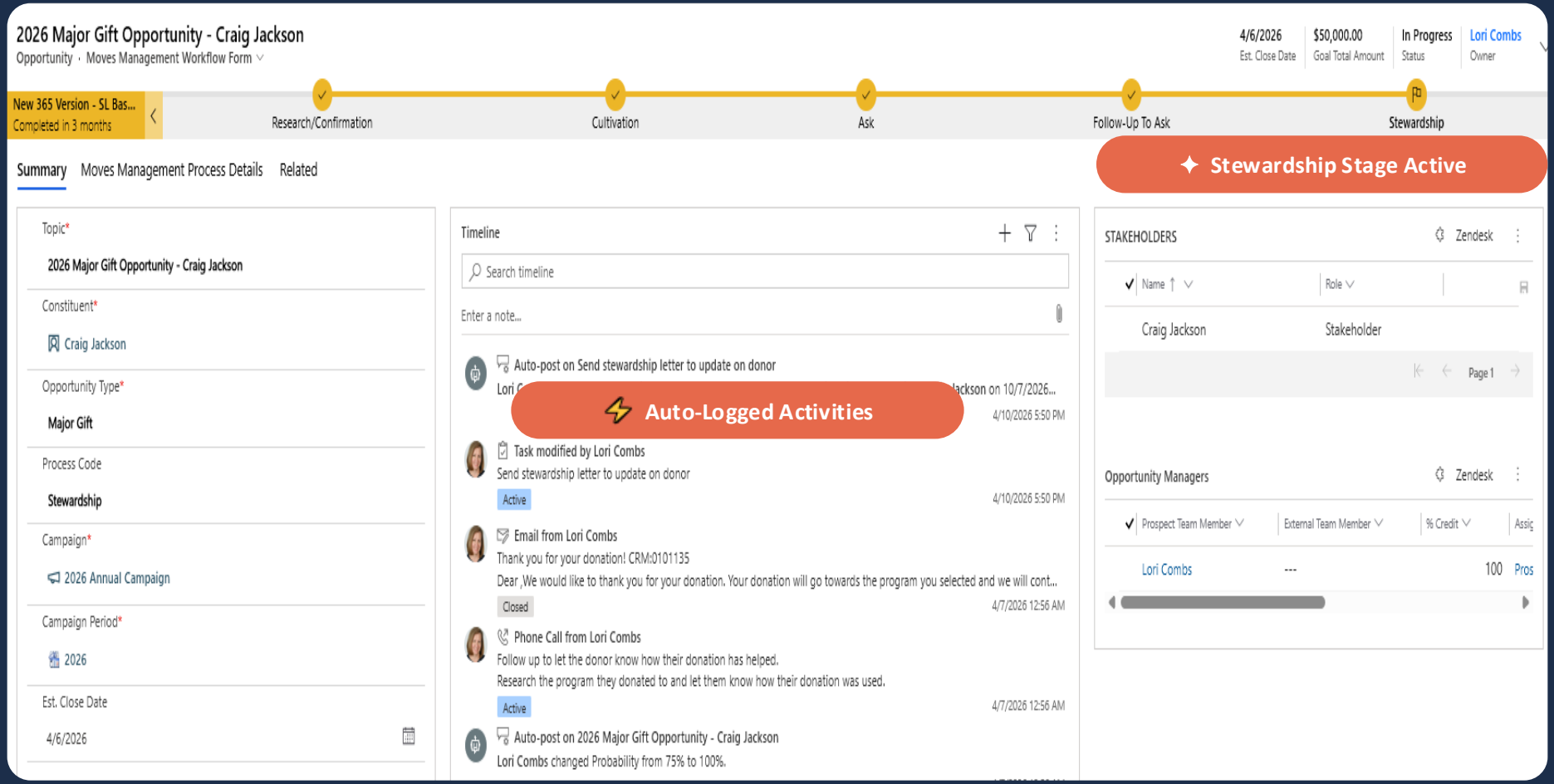
Personalized touches matched to donor level, tenure, and history

04

Engagement Invitations

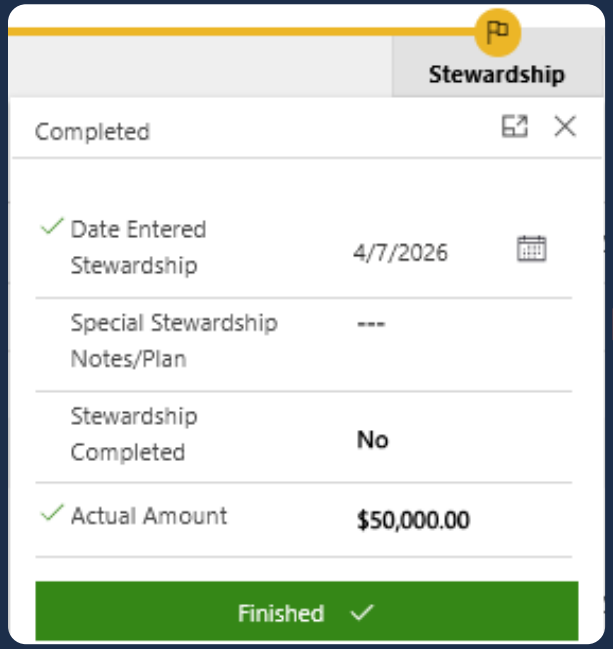
Pull donors closer with events, stories, and behind-the-scenes access

Stewardship Lifecycle — Tracked on Every Opportunity

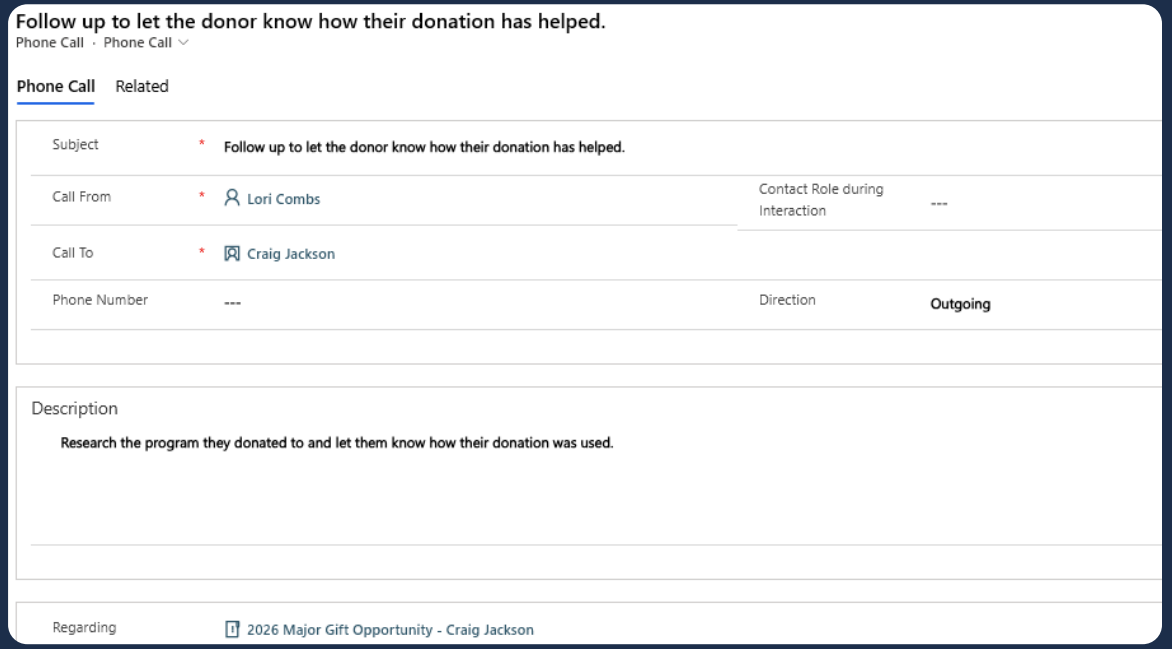


Completing the Loop – From Stage to Interaction

STEP 1
Complete Stage



STEP 2
Log the Interaction



The Full Donor Picture — 360° Intelligence at a Glance

Scott Armstrong

Chief Executive Officer @ Front Range Aerospace

Giving Since 2020

Volunteering S

armstronginspace1@gmail.com

Engagement

Engagement Score: 68 (Rank 1,011 of 307,349 ...

Current Loyal Donor

Recency Range: 0-6 Months

✦ **Engagement Intelligence**

🗂️ 💬 Scott looks all set on profile data quality, but consider reviewing profile details and sending a friendly check-in to say hi and verify—clean data and warm relationships go hand in hand.

💌 Looks like Scott recently made a donation. Be sure to send them an acknowledgement and thank them for their generosity!

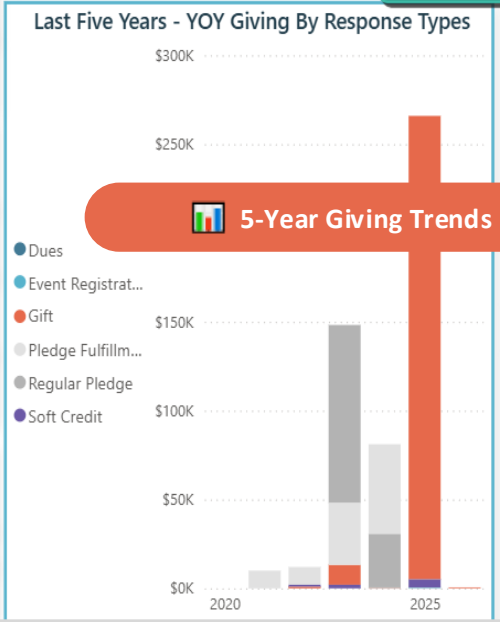
🙌 Scott is an engaged volunteer! Reach out to let them know about all the upcoming volunteer opportunities they might be excited to support.

YTD DONATIONS
$508.67
Last Year
$261,450.99

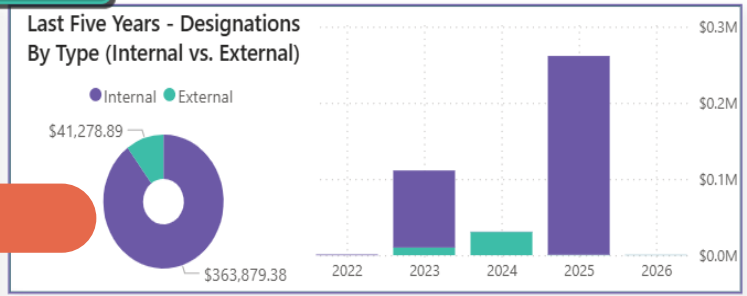
LIFETIME DONATIONS
$381,305.38
AVERAGE GIFT
$13,582.34
LARGEST GIFT
$250,000.00
SMALLEST GIFT
$51.44

LAST DONATION
03/26/2026
Gift
$200.00

Transactions



📊 **5-Year Giving Trends**



Volunteering

Activity Year	Hours
2025	
2024	
2023	3.50
Total	**37.00**

◆ **Volunteer History**

Pillar 01 — Donor Milestones

TRIGGER	RECOMMENDED ACTION
1-Year Anniversary	Handwritten note from relationship owner
5-Year Loyalty	Phone call + exclusive impact report
Cumulative $1,000	Certificate + named recognition
First Recurring Gift	Welcome to sustained giving email series
Birthday Month	Personalized story about impact
Gift Upgrade	Acknowledgment call within 48 hrs

The CRM Advantage

Every milestone can be automated as a CRM workflow trigger.

No spreadsheets. No manual tracking.

Set it once — your calendar runs itself.

Pillar 02 — Impact Updates

> *The fastest way to earn a second gift is to report back on the first.*

Designation-Matched

Use CRM designation codes to send impact content that reflects exactly what they funded — not a generic org-wide newsletter. Match content to intent.

Timed to the Gift

Schedule impact updates at 90 days and 12 months post-gift. CRM date fields make this automatable at scale across your entire donor file.

Story-Led

Lead with a beneficiary story, not a metric. Close with data. Donors connect with people, not statistics. Make your data the punchline, not the headline.

Most organizations send the same impact report to everyone. Yours doesn't have to.

Pillar 03 — Recognition That Resonates

The Recognition Ladder

Sustaining Donors

Handwritten note, annual impact call, named in report

Mid-Level Donors

Email from leadership, exclusive event invite, impact brief

Recurring Givers

Annual loyalty acknowledgment, upgrade ask timing

New / First-Time

Welcome series (3 emails), 90-day impact check-in

Recognition Principles

- Personalize to the person, not just the tier
- Match the medium to the message (call vs. email vs. card)
- Acknowledge the why, not just the what
- Tie recognition to mission impact — not org needs
- Use CRM notes to capture and recall preferences

Pillar 04 — Engagement Invitations

Stewardship isn't just communication — it's proximity. Pull donors closer.

Event Invitations

Invite mid-level and sustaining donors to behind-the-scenes tours, volunteer days, or virtual briefings before the annual fund ask.

Story Participation

Ask donors to be featured in impact stories, or invite them to meet a beneficiary. Nothing builds loyalty like being part of the narrative.

Feedback & Input

Survey donors on how they want to be communicated with, what programs matter to them. Listening is stewardship.

Peer Community

Connect loyal donors with each other through giving circles, advisory groups, or leadership councils. Community creates retention.

4

Building It

From framework to a working calendar inside your CRM.

Common Pitfalls — And How to Avoid Them

✗ Building the calendar in a spreadsheet

✓ Use CRM workflow triggers so it runs automatically

✗ One-size-fits-all messaging to all donors

✓ Segment by giving level, tenure, and designation before templating

✗ Treating stewardship as a 'nice to have'

✓ Attach it to retention goals and track it like a KPI

✗ Starting with major donors and stopping there

✓ Build a lightweight track for every giving tier — even small

✗ Stewardship owned by one person

✓ Distribute touchpoints across your team with clear ownership in the CRM

✗ No feedback loop or measurement

✓ Track retention rates, upgrade rates, and response rates by cohort quarterly

Building Your Stewardship Calendar in Your CRM

1

Audit Your Data

Identify which milestone fields exist — giving dates, designation codes, cumulative totals, birthdays.

2

Segment Your Audience

Group donors by tier, tenure, and engagement level. Your calendar won't be one-size-fits-all.

3

Map Touchpoint Types

Assign 3–5 touchpoints per segment across the year. Balance milestones, impact, and recognition.

4

Build the Workflows

Configure automated triggers in your CRM. Flag manual touchpoints for personal outreach.

5

Measure & Iterate

Track retention, response, and upgrade rates by cohort. Refine each quarter.

Your 30-Day Quick Start

Leave today with a clear action plan — no new budget required.

Week 1 | Data Audit

- Pull a list of every donor with a gift in the past 12 months
- Identify which CRM fields are populated: gift date, designation, contact info
- Flag the top 20% of donors for a 'high-touch' track

Week 2 | Segment & Map

- Create 3 simple segments: new donors, recurring, mid-level
- Assign 2–3 touchpoints to each segment for the next 90 days
- Identify which will be automated vs. personal

Week 3 | Build Workflows

- Configure your first automated trigger (e.g. 1-year anniversary)
- Draft one impact update email template by designation
- Set up a follow-up task for your top 20 donors

Week 4 | Launch & Measure

- Activate your first stewardship workflow
- Send personalized outreach to your top segment
- Set a calendar reminder to review results in 30 days

Group Exercise — 5 Minutes

With your table or a neighbor, map ONE stewardship touchpoint for your top donor segment — right now.

Who is your top segment?

Recurring? Mid-level? First-time major?

What milestone or moment?

Anniversary, upgrade, birthday, 90-day post-gift?

What touchpoint would you send?

Call, email, card, event invite, story?

Who owns it?

Is it automated or personal? Who's on the hook?

We'll share out — 2 volunteers to report back to the room.

Key Takeaways

01

Stewardship is a retention strategy, not a courtesy.

Organizations with structured stewardship retain 45%+ more donors year over year.

02

Your CRM already has what you need.

Giving history, milestones, and engagement signals are the raw material for a personal calendar.

03

Personalization is the differentiator.

Matching touchpoints to donor history — designation, tenure, level — is what makes donors feel seen.

04

Automate the calendar, humanize the message.

Let workflows handle timing. Let people handle warmth. Both are required.

Questions & Discussion

The gap between acknowledgment and relationship is where your next cohort of loyal donors lives.

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